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ORIGINAL PAPER

China's role in the EU's search for strategic autonomy: nonhegemonic power relations during world order transition

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Abstract
By applying an analysis framework related to historical structure developed by Robert W. Cox, the article attempts to explore China's role in the European Union (EU)'s search for strategic autonomy (SA). Moreover, it aims to understand big power relations during world order transition in a broader sense. The article argues that EU-SA is the EU's strategy to navigate through the transition in global order and to maintain its values and interests in the upcoming order. In other words, EU-SA is a hegemonic game both inside and beyond the EU. That is how China is related to EU-SA. EU-SA can be evaluated as ideas, institutions and capabilities and China has been involved in EU-SA on three interrelated levels: social forces, forms of state and global order. The author provides a comprehensive summary of several features of China–Europe relations as well as nonhegemonic power relations during world order transition.

Keywords European Union · Strategic autonomy · China–Europe relations · China–Europe–US Triangle · World power transition

1 Introduction

Since the sovereign debt crisis in 2009, the European Union (EU) has overcome multiple crises—far-right surge, migration, Brexit, two Ukraine crises, etc.—and worked diligently to find a solution. By late 2010s and early 2020s, a catchword emerged in the EU as the solution: strategic autonomy (SA).

Aside from navigating multiple crises in and around Europe, EU-SA also serves to adapt Europe to a changing strategic environment as the global order falters.

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European integration has been decisively shaped by two phases of the global order led by the United States (US). One phase was embedded liberalism and the other was neoliberalism (Ryner and Cafruny 2016). Since the global financial crisis in 2008, the neoliberal order has been increasingly challenged by populism inside the West and rising authoritarian powers around the world. The crises in and around Europe is part of the broader disorder.[1]

When the US-led order was intact, Europe had taken a strategy of "autonomy through alignment". That is, on the one hand, Europe accepted the broad parameters of the US-led global order; and on the other hand, Europe would like to secure a relatively autonomous sphere of development partially insulated from the prevailing logics of US power (Lavery and Schmid 2021, 1323). Vintage concepts such as "EU actorness" and "Fortress Europe" largely reflect the EU's long-time search for autonomy from the US.[2] When the concept of EU-SA first appeared in early 2010s (European Council 2013), it seemed to belong to that pedigree. Josep Borrell, High Representative of the EU for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy and Vice President of European Commission (HR/VP), admitted that "transatlantic relations and strategic autonomy go hand in hand; they are two sides of the same coin" (Borrell 2020a).

In comparison, China's role in EU-SA is much more ambiguous and has not yet been thoroughly explored by academics.

First, on the structural level, Europe has historically exerted influence over China, rather than being influenced by it. Nevertheless, entering the twenty-first century, China has become a rising superpower, pretending to redefine global order. China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) is seen by German diplomats as "globalization with Chinese characteristics" (Clauss 2017; FTChinese 2017). The complex interplay between Chinese "state capitalism" and the so-called "illiberal democracies" in Eastern Europe is seen as a source of concern for Brussels (Rogers 2022; Santander and Vlassis 2021; Karásková et al. 2020). Europe, a norm-giver rather than a norm-taker for centuries, for the first time has to fathom what China brings to the European project as well as to the world order. Moreover, the US pivot to China made it essential for Europe to define its own global position. In the EU-SA discourse, US–China antagonism has been frequently mentioned.[3] By and large, Europe has proposed that it would stand in the middle between China and the US, though closer to the US (Casarini 2022).[4] Nevertheless, Europe is aware that the faltering global order will not be quickly replaced by a new one, be it led by the US or China. Rather, there will be a "multi-order world" or a "multiplex world order" (Caffarena 2017; Acharya 2017). Therefore, as a player interested in maintaining the liberal character of the global order, Europe should "steadily engage

[1] Internal contestation, regional fragmentation and multipolar competition have been recognized as non-mutually exclusive contextual factors that make it harder for the EU and its member states to give direction, content and sustainability to EU Foreign Security Policy and especially provide a coherent response to conflicts and crises. See Alcaro and Dijkstra (2024).

[2] See Allen and Smith (1990), Lavery (2024).

[3] French President Emmanuel Macron is a good example in this case. See Le Grand Continent (2020).

[4] Among EU politicians, European Union HR/VP Josep Borrell has contributed extensively to this topic. See Borrell (2020b, c, d).

in the process leading to its establishment. This involvement will help Europe gain and retain full membership while enhancing their discursive power" (Caffarena 2017, 1).

Second, on the bilateral level, China has developed an intimate relationship with Europe during the boom years of the neoliberal order. Economic, technology and people-to-people exchanges between China and Europe have reached a formidable scale. Any strategic move by the EU will likely be ineffective without China's cooperation. Or to put it differently, the interaction between China and Europe over EU-SA will to an extent determine the outcome of EU-SA. However, the relationship between China and Europe has become tumultuous and intriguing in recent years. The EU redefined its relations with China in early 2019, referring China simultaneously as a cooperation partner, a negotiating partner, an economic competitor and a systemic rival (European Commission and High Representative of the EU for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy 2019, 1). But China does not accept such tripartite re-orientation, describing the situation as being "like driving to a crossing and finding the red, yellow and green lights all on at the same time" (Xinhua 2024). Though China and the EU reach political consensus on Comprehensive Agreement on Investment (CAI) in late 2020, demonstrating their strong commercial ties as ever, the agreement has been blocked by the European Parliament due to divergence over Xinjiang and human rights issues. The coronavirus pandemic, which broke out in spring 2020, has served as a wake-up call for Europe, highlighting the impact of Chinese domestic affairs on the continent—something Europeans had largely overlooked until now. In addition, the Ukraine war, which broke out 2 years later, has had a similar effect for Europe, highlighting that any Chinese geopolitical maneuver could potentially impact Europe's security, another fact that Europeans had previously seldom contemplated (Raik et al. 2024, 46).

Third, on the discursive level, EU-SA remains a fluid and ambiguous concept. Borrell pointed out after a failed attempt to clarify EU-SA in a foreign ministers' gathering that, the concept was born on the field of defense and security, but it has been used "almost everywhere" and reached "almost everything". Some people prefer "open strategic autonomy" in order to avoid autarchy or protectionism while some people prefer the seemingly stronger word "sovereignty" (Borrell 2020e).

Thus, a proper frame is required to illustrate China's role in EU-SA. The author will first build up a theoretical frame about power relations during world order transition primarily based on the Gramcian School of International Relations, and then try to answer the following questions: (1) What factors related to China have been in play in building up the idea of EU-SA? (2) What measures related to EU-SA have been designed with China as a particular target? And do these measures work? (3) How China sees and reacts to EU-SA? Does this have an impact on EU-SA? (4) What is the likely future of China's role in EU-SA? (5) What does the above say about nonhegemonic relations during world order transition and the coming new order?

2 World order transition and the change of power relations

2.1 World order transition: background of EU-SA

Since the global financial crisis in 2008, the neoliberal order has been seriously challenged. Although it persisted for a few years, by 2016, its decline became undeniable.[5] In the summer of 2016, the United Kingdom (UK) held a referendum and decided to leave the EU, taunting the world's most successful regional integration project. Right wing populist politician Donald Trump won the US presidential election at the end of 2016, exposing the deep rift in American society. Over the following several years, China loomed large into the picture. President Trump launched a series of trade and technology wars with China as the two superpowers began to decouple. Trade and investment became weaponized and geopoliticsed. All these seismic events—Brexit, Trump and US–China antagonism—constitute a unique world - historical conjuncture, signaling a turbulent world order transition. Crises are interconnected across global, national, and societal levels, and their effects are likely to last for an extended period of time. Consequently, the term "interregnum," coined by Antonio Gramsci, once again became pertinent (Babic 2020).

EU-SA is the European continent's answer to the order transition. To fully grasp EU-SA, one must first understand the nature of order transition.

According to Robert W. Cox (1926–2018), a key figure pioneering the Gramscian approach to International Political Economy, a principal distinction between structures of world order lies in whether or not the order is hegemonic. By hegemony, he refers to "dominance of a particular kind where the dominant state creates and order based ideologically on a broad measure of consent, functioning according to general principles that in fact ensure the continuing supremacy of the leading state or states and leading social classes but at the same time offer some measure or prospect of satisfaction to the less powerful" (Cox 1987, 7). A world hegemonic order can be founded only by a country inside which social hegemony has been or is being achieved (Ibid, 149–150). In our context, such a country is the US. After the Second World War, the US built an embedded liberal order. The order was interrupted by economic recession in the 1970s, but was succeeded by a US-led neoliberal order in the early 1980s.[6] In the heyday of the US-led neoliberal order, economics was separated from politics both inside the US and globally; the political foundations of hegemonic economic order are so taken for granted and practically ignored (Cox 1987, 150). Some Marxist scholars called this an "empire" of capitalism (Hardt and Negri 2000, 332; Wood 2003). Even Scholars from the neoliberal IR school admitted that "American hegemony is penetrated" (Deudney and Ikenberry 1999).

But a hegemonic order does not last forever. It can be succeeded by a unified and consensual, homogeneous, hegemonic order or towards a fragmented and conflictual, heterogeneous, nonhegemonic order. When the world is entering a nonhegemonic order, the erstwhile hegemon's simultaneous grip of ideas, institutions and

[5] See Crouch (2011), Peck (2013) and Barnett (2021).

[6] See two following classic works: Ruggie (1982) and Harvey (2005).

material capabilities begin to loosen up, both at home and abroad.[7] That is why we have seen chaotic political thoughts, social conflicts and disarrayed institutions in the US, Europe and the rest of the world in recent years. Moreover, in a nonhegemonic order, the economic-productive structures of social formations lose their compatibility with the hegemonic world economy. Social classes and the organization of production revolve more exclusively around the state. States advance and protect the interests of particular national social classes and production organizations, using all available political, economic, and military means as necessary (Cox 1987, 7–8, 209–210).

Soon after the global financial crisis in 2008 and European sovereign debt crisis in 2009, "economic patriotism" emerged in the Western world, albeit some western capitals promoted liberal along with protectionist measures (Clift and Woll 2012). By early 2010s, "competitive authoritarian capitalism" and "state bureaucratic capitalism", typically observed in the non-Western world, have been noticeably competing with "liberal democratic capitalism" and "social democratic capitalism" (Buzan and Lawson 2014). By early 2020s, the category "state capitalism" has become "a central geopolitical marker" (Alami and Dixon 2020) with China's "party-state capitalism" facing notable international backlash (Pearson et al. 2022). Some countries have established their own brands of state tinted capitalism inside Europe, such as Hungary's "ordonationalism" (Geva 2021). Meanwhile, countries have once again been reasserting traditional state sovereignty. The older "extralegal" and "organic" versions of sovereignty are said to have been reaffirmed by Russia, China, and the US. That is, they offer few constraints on state action and license powerful states to dominate others (Roland 2020). Russia's aggression against Ukraine is the most noticeable example of this.

In light of these circumstances, the EU has to strengthen its actorness versus internal and external players. Though the EU is not a state, it faces similar challenges. That is why it has proposed such concepts as autonomy, sovereignty, derisking, etc. in recent years. EU-SA can be understood on three levels: national, European and global. On the national level, EU-SA is a slogan designed to take the brunt of domestic populism. Flirting with the populist idea, SA usually means prioritizing the practice of protecting national interests. On the European level, EU-SA is a mixed bag of ideas catering to a variety of economic models and diverging foreign policy goals of different EU Member States, thus maintaining the momentum of the European project. On the global level, EU-SA is the tool for European strategic elites to navigate in a treacherous new world of geopolitical competition.

2.2 Nonhegemonic relations counts: how EU-SA concerns both Europe and China

In the apex of the hegemonic order, the relationships between the hegemon and nonhegemonic powers are relatively clear-cut and stable. The hegemon runs the

[7] Dominance by a powerful state may be a necessary but not a sufficient condition of hegemony. Hegemony is a fit between power, ideas and institutions at the same times. Such understanding makes it possible to deal with some of the problems in the theory of state dominance as the necessary condition for a stable international order; it allows for lags and leads in hegemony. See Cox (1981, 138–141).

system and every country's location in the system is defined by its relation with the hegemon. For example, the world order was maintained in the 1980s by a coalition "centering upon the United States, the Federal Republic of Germany, and Japan, with the support of other OECD states, the co-optation of a few of the more industrialized third World Countries […] and the possibility of revived détente allowing for a greater linkage of the Soviet sphere into the economy of international production" (Cox 1981, 149). Nonhegemonic powers naturally regard their relations with the hegemon as the most important bilateral relationship.

By contrast, when the hegemonic order rattles, nonhegemonic powers cease to view the hegemon as a key reference point. They strive to become or bet on the new hegemon. They will seek and form new coalitions and tap into new cleavages. The relationship between major powers during a world order transition becomes more dynamic and plays a more decisive role in the system. The current China–Europe relationship exemplifies this evolving dynamic. The change from a hegemonic order to a nonhegemonic order is a major reason why China and Europe pay more attention to each other today. This transition also explains why global strategists pay more attention to the China–Europe relationship.

Cox has not delved into nonhegemonic power relations, be they a part of the hegemonic or nonhegemonic order. However, recent scholars have provided us an interdisciplinary typology to study power in relation to structural change. They divide power relations into three types and scrutinize their relations, respectively, in balance and imbalance situations (see Table 1) (Avelino and Rotmans 2009). It is safe to argue that the relationship between China and Europe falls into Type 2, that is, they have "more" or "less" power; when they have a balanced relationship, they tend to cooperate and when they have imbalanced power, they tend to compete with each other. In contrast, the EU–Russia relationship arguably falls into Type 3, that is, they have a "different" power and their relationship, if imbalanced, will go from synergy to antagonism.

EU-SA can be understood as the EU's strategy to gain an upper hand as its relationships with other principal powers shift from balanced to imbalanced. During a world order transition, such adjustments among powers are most likely to occur.

Table 1 Typology of power relations. Source: Avelino and Rotmans (2009, 557)

Type of power relation	Balance	Imbalance
Type 1: Having power 'over'	A depends on B but B also depends on A, so A and B have power over each other = mutual dependency	A depends on B but B does not depend on A, so B has power over A = one-sided dependency
Type 2: Having 'more' or 'less' power	A mobilizes more resources than B, but A and B have goals that are collective or co-exist = co-existence/cooperation	A mobilizes more resources than B, while A and B have mutually exclusive goals = competition
Type 3: Having a 'different' power	A exercise power in such a way that it enables and enforces the power exercised by B = synergy	A exercises power in such a way that it disrupts or prevents power exercised by B = antagonism

2.3 Ideas and relations: how the story between EU-SA and China unfolds

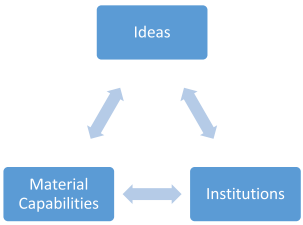
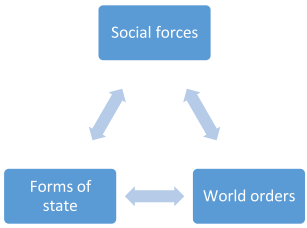
EU-SA is a bunch of influencing ideas concerning Europe's role in the world and its interactions on the global stage. Many think tanks, EU institutions and European capitals have come together to contribute to this discussion. There have been several phases of the debate, each with a different focus. From 2013 to 2016, EU-SA was mainly seen as an approach to security and defense matters. From 2017 to 2019, it was considered as a way to defend European interests in a hostile geopolitical environment, with Brexit, the Trump presidency and deteriorating US–China relationship as the backdrop. In 2020, the Covid-19 pandemic shifted the focus to mitigating economic dependence on foreign supply chains. Since 2021, the scope of EU-SA has been widened to virtually all EU policy areas. Since the Russian invasion of Ukraine in February 2022, steps towards achieving EU-SA have accelerated, while the concept nevertheless remains blurred by the variation in terminology (Damen 2022).

Ideas have consequence. Three forces—ideas, institutions and material capabilities—interact with each other and together decide a historical structure. If a country or a coalition of countries wants to establish global hegemony, it has to build a prevailing historical structure. If a country or a coalition of countries wants to resist the prevailing historic structure, it will buttress their actions with an alternative, emerging configuration of forces, a rival structure (Cox 1981, 135–137). Therefore, EU-SA has the potential to strengthen according institutions and material capabilities; it can also be used as a tool to build or resist historical structure on a global scale. In this sense, EU-SA is of significant concern to China, which cannot afford to ignore its implications.

China's interaction with EU-SA will extend beyond state-level interactions. Cox points out that the transformation of a historical structure of world order is a complex process involving change in the relative powers of the principal states, alongside with a new distribution of productive powers among social formations, the formation of new historic blocs, and new social relations of production and new mechanisms of capital accumulation (Cox 1987, 209). More specifically, the interaction between China and Europe over EU-SA, and more broader context of the new historical structure will take place on three levels, or spheres of activity: (1) the organization of production, more particularly with regard to the social forces engendered by the production process; (2) forms of state (in our case, forms of state as well as the European regional integration structure); and (3) world orders (See Cox 1981, 137–138).

In summary, Cox has prepared two triangles related to historical structure, which serve as proper tools for us to illustrate how EU-SA ideas interplay with China–Europe relationship against the backdrop of world order transition. The first triangle is three elements building up a historical structure: ideas, institutions and material capabilities. The second triangle is three spheres of activities (or three levels of analysis) where the elements interact: social forces, forms of state, world orders (see Table 2). The two triangles will be applied to the following analysis in the article.

Table 2 Historical structure triangles. Source: Cox (1981, 136, 138)

Elements of a historical structure	Spheres of activities(levels of analysis)
	

3 EU-SA and China: ideas, institutions and capabilities

Though the EU has never been very explicit about which "Other" it seeks autonomy from or how it intends to achieve this, it is safe to argue that, the EU wants to seek autonomy primarily from US military dominance, Chinese economic dependence and Russian security threats. Due to the interconnection of major powers, China looms behind every bilateral relationship between the EU and other major powers. By 2022, the year when the Ukraine war erupted, European politicians had identified three areas they wanted to seek autonomy from China: values, economic security and strategic security. In recent years, the EU has been building up its institutions to support this goal. The outcome of these efforts has been a partial success.

3.1 Rising China awareness

The development of EU-SA discourse can be divided into several phases. Initially, China's role in EU-SA was not clearly defined, but gradually increased over time. During the process, Europe's attitude towards China shifted from basically cooperative to basically competitive.

Phase 1: Autonomy from the US security umbrella (2013–2016). The first official EU document which included the term SA was the European Council conclusion on the EU's Common Security and Defense Policy (CSDP) in December 2013. It stated that strengthening Europe's defense industry can "enhance its strategic autonomy and its ability to act with partners" (European Council 2013). As the US pivoted to Asia in early 2010s, the EU realized that it should build up its own defense capabilities. For a long time, however, the term EU-SA had rarely been used. It was not until 2016 that SA was mentioned again in the EU Global Strategy (EUGS), which stated that: "an appropriate level of ambition and strategic autonomy is important for Europe's ability to promote peace and security within and beyond its borders" (European Union 2016, 9). The editorial board of *The New York Times* considered EUGS to be partially aimed at "reducing Europe's reliance on the United States in Europe" (The New York Times 2016).

China was not a focus of EUGS, nor was China seen as a major security player, be it a partner or threat. Instead, the EU seemed to be very interested in "China's

connectivity drives westwards", referring to China's BRI, and said that it would "pursue a coherent approach to China's connectivity drives westwards by maximizing the potential of the EU–China Connectivity Platform". The EUGS argued that "peace and stability in Asia are a prerequisite for our prosperity", putting forward a suggestion that aimed to enhance economic cooperation (European Union 2016, 37–38).

In summary, EU-SA in the beginning focused on security and the US was the most significant "Other" in this phase. China was a secondary player, either by diverting US attention from Europe or by ominously infiltrating Europe's neighborhood with its growing economic clout. Subconsciously, the EU began to worry about its actorness toward China, which was reflected in its call for "a coherent approach" to China in the EUGS. Nevertheless, the EU continued to view economic cooperation as the most viable policy toward China.

Phase 2: Autonomy from the US–China antagonism (2017–2019). Since 2017, the EU has encountered a very different environment. Trump was the first post-war US president that considered North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) as "obsolete" and to advocate for the breakdown of the EU (The Times 2017). Angela Merkel, then German Chancellor, vowed that "the times in which we can fully count on others" was over and Europeans must "take our destiny in our own hands" (Rachman 2017). There seemed to be a window of opportunity for Europe and China to join hands against Trump in early 2017. Chinese President Xi Jinping's warning against a rising wave of protectionism at the World Economic Forum in Davos in January was especially well received in Europe (Donahue 2017). Nevertheless, the opportunity slipped away as the Europeans worried that Beijing did not practice what it preached—as seen in the EU's first report on "significant distortions in the economy" of China in mid-2017—and that the bargain between China and the US would undermine the rules-based world system (European Commission 2017; Stephens 2017).

The years from 2017 to 2019 marked Europe's strategic awakening. In September 2017, the newly-elect French president Emmanuel Macron gave a speech on new initiative for Europe in Sorbonne University, proposing "a sovereign Europe" (Macron 2017a, b). His idea was echoed one year later by then European Commission president Jean-Claude Juncker in his State of the Union speech entitled "the hour of European sovereignty" (Juncker 2018). Numerous think tank articles on European sovereignty and autonomy have since been published.[8] By the end of 2019, EU-SA became the zeitgeist for the EU. The new European Commission president Ursula von der Leyen vowed to build a "geopolitical commission" (European Commission 2019).

When the debate on SA still to some extent focused on the US in 2018, by the second half of 2019, the US–China stand-off had dominated the debate.[9] The year of 2019 had witnessed Europeans fretting over "to use Chinese 5G or not" when pressured by the two superpowers. Macron argued at the ambassadors' conference in August that: "Europe

[8] For example, Franke and Varma (2018), Brustlein (2018), Lippert et al. (2019), and Fiott (2018).

[9] In mid-2018, think tank report claimed that "the debate on European strategic autonomy remains overly focused on US criticism of the EU". In mid-2019, another think tank report pointed out that: "Europe's strategic autonomy in some major policy fields, and relates the question of strategic autonomy to the partnerships of the EU with the US and China." See: Franke and Varma (2018, 1), and Grevi (2019, 5).

will disappear with the obliteration of this Western period, and the world will be centered on two main focal points: the United States and China. And we will have to choose between the two powers" (Macron 2019). EU foreign policy chief Josep Borrell asserted that "to avoid being the losers in today's US–China competition, we must relearn the language of power and conceive of Europe as a top-tier geostrategic actor" (Borrell 2020f).

It was for the first time in modern history that Europeans overwhelmingly felt the need to understand China and act accordingly. They were awed and puzzled by the change of China's domestic politics and external behavior. They regard China as having the potential to define every dimension of the global upheaval—shattering the liberal order, upcoming the technology revolution, influencing climate change, etc.[10] The EU wanted to seek autonomy from China as well as from the US. The EU changed its definition of China from a strategic partner in 2003 to simultaneously being a cooperation partner, an economic competitor and a systemic rival in early 2019, aiming to adopt a "whole-of-EU approach" toward China (European Commission and High Representative of the EU for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy 2019, 1).

It is worth noting that, unlike the US, the Europeans in 2019 saw China's growth into a superpower as a possible, eventual (not present) threat, but they did not treat it as a military threat. Military cooperation between the EU and China continued and the EU was reluctant to form a broad international coalition to contain China (Klein 2020, 43).

Phase 3: Autonomy from the Chinese economy (2020–2021). The COVID-19 pandemic of 2020 has made the EU even more eager to achieve SA. In Europe's own eyes, it had become a lonely defender of multilateralism, fighting with vulnerable supply chains, disinformation and worsening geopolitical conflicts. Josep Borrell and EU Commissioner for the Internal Market Thierry Breton published an article on the EU's reaction to the coronavirus crisis and the lessons learned "for a united, resilient and sovereign Europe". They asserted that the coronavirus crisis "forcefully revives the central question of our autonomy, our sovereignty and our position as a player in world geopolitics, particularly in the face of growing tensions between the United States and China" (Borrell and Breton 2020). A report published by European Think-tank Network on China (ETNC) in early 2020 claimed that the Covid-19 crisis "represents the first time that China has figured so prominently on an issue of immediately critical importance to European citizens, governments, and the European project more broadly." The report argued that China was likely to work as "a catalyst for the emergence of a more geopolitical Europe" (Seaman 2020, 5, 9).

Since the pandemic, EU-SA has come to encompass almost all aspects of EU policy, from economics, technology, values to diplomacy and defense. Concepts similar to SA have emerged, such as "open-SA" favored by the trade sector, "technology sovereignty" favored by the technology sector, "strategic sovereignty" and "capability to act" favored by the strategic circle and "resilience" favored by the industry, rendering the exact meaning of SA increasingly ambiguous. Among those concepts, "open-SA" and "resilience" were particularly relevant to China. Europe faced

[10] French President Macron's sensational speech at the ambassadors' conference in 2019 was very typical in this regard. See Macron (2019).

a significant shortage of personal protective equipment due to the pandemic and had to rely on China for supplies (Reuters 2020). Europe also worried about China's possible take-over of European assets during the pandemic (Brunsden 2020).

In sum, the pandemic has highlighted the downside of Europe's interdependence with China. The EU began to further change its policies of trade, investment, industry, state aid, competition and other areas to address this issue. The EU's pursuit for autonomy and its relations with China began to entangle.[11]

Phase 4: Autonomy to survive great power games (2022–2024). The war in Ukraine, which broke out in February 24, 2022, has posed the gravest ever test for EU-SA. While China was not a direct participant in the Ukraine war, it has been regarded by NATO as a potential disruptor of European security and of the world order, largely due to China's close relationship with Russia.[12] The EU has not changed its perception of China as "a partner for cooperation, an economic competitor and a systemic rival", as seen in its Strategic Compass launched one month after the outbreak of the war (Versailles Declaration 2022, 17–18). But the EU has adjusted "the relative weights among these three items". European politicians began to re-calibrate "our stance (with China) across three clusters of issues: values, economic security and strategic security" (Borrell 2023a). First, regarding values, Borrell argued that the EU was facing "a fierce battle of narratives", thus the EU should not only learn the language of power, but be able to "speak it" (Borrell 2022). Second, in regards to economic security, German Foreign Minister Annalena Baerbock bluntly points out that: "Complete economic dependence, especially on countries that do not share our values, is a security risk" (German Federal Foreign Office 2022). The Europeans worry that while accelerating their green transition, reliance on Russia's oil and gas would turn into reliance on China's solar panels and rare earth materials (Wieringen and Hüntemann 2022; Bermingham 2023a). Third, in regards to strategic security, Berlin asserted in its first China strategy paper in July 2023 that "developments in the Indo-Pacific can have a direct impact on Euro-Atlantic security" (German Federal Government 2023). The EU and Japan vowed at their summit in the same month that the security of Europe and that of the Indo-Pacific were "closely interlinked" and they opposed "any unilateral attempts to change the status quo by force or coercion anywhere" (Council of the European Union 2023). However, some are concerned that focusing too heavily on Asia, particularly in relation to the Taiwan

[11] As a European think tank report puts it, "Europe today is clearly in the midst of searching for a balance between openness and security—between yielding the benefits of interdependence and reducing the vulnerabilities of dependence. This is not a process that is solely about China, but it is nevertheless one that will fundamentally impact relations with it." See Seaman et al. (2022, 9).

[12] The Strategic Concept of NATO published in June 2022 clearly stated that: "The deepening strategic partnership between the People's Republic of China and the Russian Federation and their mutually reinforcing attempts to undercut the rules-based international order run counter to our values and interests." See NATO (2022).

issue, could turn Europe into a "vassal" of the US, thus damaging EU-SA. French president Macron is the most famous proponent of this view.[13]

In sum, following the Ukraine war, the EU has become more assertive toward China on many fronts in order to enhance EU-SA, from values, economy to security, although EU Member States might not see eye to eye with each other on concrete moves.

3.2 Building up institutions

As Europe's awareness of China increases, the EU is establishing institutions that focus significantly on China. Institutionalization is a means of stabilizing and perpetuating the order that favors the EU by integrating both ideas and material capabilities.

The most noticeable area is "economic security". The coronavirus pandemic and the Ukraine war have linked EU-SA with the EU's economic safeguarding measures against China.[14] Since 2022, the EU has been quickened its pace on putting out regulations, acts, directives, initiatives to safeguard its economic advantages (see Table 3). The EU launched economic security strategy in 2023 (European Commission 2023). The idea of creating a European Economic Security Committee has also been floated among policy makers.[15]

The second area of institutionalization is related to values and morns. In December 2020, the EU put forward EU Global Human Rights Sanctions Regime, which is considered as the European version of the US Global Magnitsky Human Rights Accountability Act of 2016. The EU sanctioned four Chinese officials and an entity over Xinjiang human rights issues in March the next year by citing the sanction regime. Many economic-related initiatives and regulations, such as the Global Gateway (2022) (European Commission 2021a) and Corporate Sustainability Due Diligence Directive (2024) have a clear value bias against China. In June 2022, Global Gateway joined Partnership for Global Infrastructure and Investment (PGII), a program designed by the US and G7 to win over the Global South and to counter China's BRI (Leyen 2022).

The third area of institutionalization is related to the military. In September 2021, the EU put forward its Indo-Pacific strategy, which stated that the situation in the South and East China Sea and in the Taiwan Strait "may have a direct impact on European security and prosperity" (European Commission and High Representative

[13] On his plane from China back to France in 2023, President Macron claimed to the press that Europe must reduce its dependency on the US and avoid getting dragged into a confrontation between China and the US over Taiwan. He said the great risk Europe faced was that it got "caught up in crises that are not ours, which prevented it from building its strategic autonomy". See Amilanderlini and Caulcutt (2023).

[14] Europe has been complaining China over economic issues since 2016, when there was a dispute about China's Market Economic Status and steel overproduction. In the next three years, the EU amended Regulations on dumped and subsidized imports and put forward a foreign investment screening framework. But these measures have not been particularly linked to EU-SA.

[15] See Steinberg and Wolff (2024). The authors presented key results of their research to the informal meeting of EU Finance Ministers at Santigo de Compostela, Spain, September 2023.

Table 3 EU-SA-related economic measures since 2022

Area	Name (effective year)	Aims to	The China factor
Technology	Chips Act (2023)	Increase the EU's share of the global chip market	These acts are primarily targeted at the US, but also at China, aiming to improve European competitiveness in technology, standards and regulations against the backdrop of fierce US–China technology competition
	Data Act (2022)	Facilitate data sharing between businesses and between businesses and governments	
	Data Markets Act (2022)	Check digital market "gatekeepers" and make the market more competitive	
	Digital Service Act (2024)	Regulate digital content, advertising and disinformation	
	Artificial Intelligence Act (2024)	Regulate AI (the first such regulation in the world)	
	Strategic Technologies for Europe Platform (2024)	Promote critical technology investment	
Trade and Investment	International Procurement Instrument (2022)	Seek reciprocity in government procurement	The EU wants to get access to the Chinese market
	Corporate Sustainability Due Diligence Directive (2024)	Punish human rights violations and environmental damage in the supply chain	The EU wants to follow US on checking "forced labor" in Xinjiang, China
	Regulation on Prohibiting Products Made with Forced Labour on the Union Market (2024)		
	Critical Raw Material Act (2024)	Secure the supply of critical raw material	The EU wants to break China's monopoly of rare earth
	Foreign Subsidies Regulation (2023)	Regulate state subsidies for third-country enterprises with operations in the EU	The EU wants to limit Chinese companies' activities in Europe
	Anti-Coercion Instrument (2023)	Deter economic coercion by third countries	This is mainly a response to China's "coercion" against Lithuania
Green transition	Net-Zero Industry Act (2024)	Promote investment in products that are key to achieving the EU's climate neutrality target	The EU wants to counter the US's Inflation Reduction Act which provides state aids and, to a lesser extent, China's "overproduction"
	Temporary Crisis and Transition Framework (2023)		
	Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism (2023)	Charge on steel, aluminum, cement, fertilizers, etc. exported to the EU from third countries	The EU wants to take advantage of green regulation against US, China, India, etc

of the EU for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy 2021a, 2). The Strategy suggested "(e)xploring ways to ensure enhanced naval deployments by EU Member States" in the Indo-Pacific (Ibid., 17).

3.3 Where is the muscle

The gap between capability and ambition has long existed in EU foreign policy (Chaban and Elgstrom 2023; Lai et al. 2023). Chinese scholars have mixed feelings towards the future of EU-SA, ranging from optimistic, pessimistic and prudent (Yang 2023). The suspicion is even stronger across the Atlantic. A US think tank asked in the wake of the Ukraine war: "Is European strategic autonomy over?" (Dempsey 2023) Aside from dwindling military power, Europe's economy is not in good shape. In 2008, the eurozone and the US had equivalent gross domestic products (GDP); in 2023, the eurozone's GDP had fallen to just 80% of that of the US (Leparmentier 2023). The EU has acknowledged that slowing growth, driven by declining productivity, is "calling into question Europe's ability to meet its ambitions" (European Commission 2024, 8). Europe's status in the global power system has also declined. China and other emerging powers have been gaining "structural power"; this has mostly come at the relative expense of Europe, however, rather than the US (Winecoff 2020).

To gauge whether there is a capacity-ambition gap of EU-SA, it's essential to first clarify what that ambition entails. In the *2021 Strategic Foresight Report* published by the European Commission, the EU states that it wants to pursue "global leadership towards 2050" and it sees itself as "an interconnected global pole in a multipolar world". While the EU cannot be certain as to "what the future holds", it wants to "work towards the most favorable scenario to preserve and enhance the EU's capacity and freedom to act". "The EU will not turn inwards but will remain firm on its principles and values and agile in its conduct", added the report (European Commission 2021b, 30). In other words, EU-SA represents the EU's strategy to navigate through order transition and to maintain its values and interests in the upcoming order. Although the EU aspires to be a major player in this emerging hegemonic coalition, it lacks a clear understanding of what the future holds.

By this standard, we can argue that EU-SA is not a complete failure. Without exerting itself too much into the world, the EU has managed to retain much of what it has established. First, though the Ukraine war has set a de facto border for the European project, it has strengthened the unity of the EU Member States. Second, though the EU has fallen behind the two economic superpowers in the forefront of technology competition, it is still a leader in standard-setting. Europe's economic safeguarding measures towards China have partly achieved their goal. For example, under the pressure from the EU, China has recently dropped "economic coercion" measures against Lithuania (Bermingham 2024). Third, scholars find that the EU has proven to be rather successful in defending existing international multilateral institutions, though it has largely failed to reform and further extend them to new areas (Schuette and Dijkstra 2023).

4 EU-SA and China: social forces, forms of state and world orders

The development of EU-SA occurs as the EU engages with China, with this interaction taking place on a continental scale and unfolding across various levels. During global order transition, the interactions become increasingly intense and paradoxical,

reorganizing around the centrality of states (EU Member States, the European Commission and the Chinese state). Various social forces from Europe, China and even other countries join in the process. The outcome of the interaction will play an important role in defining the coming new global order.

4.1 Inner struggle within Europe

Interests and worldview have grown increasingly diversified and contentious inside both Europe and China over the last decade.[16] However, unlike Europe, China is relatively a unified actor. China–Europe relations have mirrored the internal divisions within Europe more than those within China.

France is the EU Member State that has arguably contributed the most in building up the concept of EU-SA. France has two primary objectives in EU-SA. Militarily, its goal is to gain European independence from the US, thus enhancing Paris' clout on European strategic issues. Economically, its goal is to legitimize France's protectionist proposals on the EU level (Bora 2023), most of which are directed against China. Beijing chooses to encourage the first and to neglect the latter when talking up EU-SA to Paris. China–France relationship remains strong against the turbulence of China–Europe ties partly due to their common sponsorship of EU-SA. In a visit to China in April 2023, Macron told Xi that "France does not pick sides" (Lau 2023; Xinhua 2023a). Three months later, Macron successfully blocked NATO from opening an office in Japan, the first ever in Asia, in NATO summit in Vilnius (Lau and Kayali 2023). Xi acclaimed during his visit to France in May 2024 that because of "independence and autonomy", "China and France are special friends".[17]

Compared to France, Germany holds a more open view on trade and investment and its economy is more intertwined with China. In General, Germany has been less active than France in raising tariffs and restricting imports from China. Nevertheless, Germany's influence on EU-SA is not as clear-cut as France and the concept remains contentious within the country. German big international firms, who have been heavily invested in China (Dominguez 2022), support an open market and favor a more pragmatic approach towards China. However, median and small companies prefer a more protective approach. In early 2019, the German Ministry of Economic Affairs revealed its National Industrial Strategy 2030. The strategy indicates a strategic re-orientation within key sectors of the German power bloc, focusing on actively promoting "technological sovereignty" and "European champions". However, this re-orientation is deeply contested, revealing growing divisions within German capital along diverging competitive positions and patterns of internationalization (Schneider 2023a, b). Germany's perceived lack of "strategic thinking" may

[16] See Schweiger and Magone (2014); Biermann (2023); Guan and Yang (2020); Qin (2021); Shi-Kupfer et al. (2017).

[17] He mentioned Charles De Gaulle, former French president who built diplomatic ties with China in the 1960s, and asserted that "independence has been a strong factor behind every high moment in Sino-French relations." See Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs (2024a).

explain why Beijing has engaged less with Berlin on EU-SA compared to France. Instead, Beijing seems more inclined to discuss "de-risking" with Berlin.[18]

In recent years, small countries on the European periphery have begun to develop their own China policies, moving away from the previous practice of relying on the EU to shape their approach. Interestingly, China has tactically talked up EU-SA with some peripheral European countries that have been regarded as a spoiler of EU-SA within Europe (Müller and Gazsi 2023). For example, Chinese diplomats have frequently referred to EU-SA or "independence" with their Hungarian counterparts (Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs 2023c, 2024a, b). Hungary's relatively detached attitude towards the transatlantic alliance might have made Beijing feel more at ease with its leaders.[19] In addition, thanks to the locality-specific blend of development processes in the region**,** such as state-business relations and the shared experiences of state-socialism**,** Central and Eastern European Countries (CEEC) sometimes have a more favorable view of China than Western European countries (Rogers 2022). Hungary has in particular built up in recent years a novel regime of "illiberal democracy" or "Ordonationalism", whose emphasis of the nation-state in political and economic activities made it more similar to China (Geva 2021; Financial Times 2014).

China's cozying up with the CEEC bloc used to get on Brussels' nerves. However, the Ukraine war has strained China's ties with most CEECs. Baltic countries have withdrawn from the China-CEEC cooperation mechanism and the China-CEEC annual summit has not been held since 2022.

A big winner from EU-SA is the EU itself. EU institutions, especially the European Commission, have seized powers from Member States in the name of EU-SA (Öberg 2023). Within EU institutions, there are divisions regarding EU-SA. In the European Commission, the Directorate-General for Trade is the most vocal advocate of "free trade", but its position is often constrained by other institutions (Christou and Damro 2024). "Resilience" and "open strategic autonomy" is a compromise between different positions (Jacobs et al. 2023). Beijing has noticed the growing power of the EU and had expressed its hope that EU-SA could "embody the formulation and implementation of the correct policies towards China" (Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs 2020). But Beijing prefers dealing with the European council (representing the Member States) rather than the European Commission (the executive branch of the EU), since the latter is more aligned with the US on "de-risking" with China (Lynch and Mones 2023).

While the right-wing populist notion of sovereigntism may have inspired aspects of the EU-SA, populist movements in Europe do not contribute to it. These movements typically advocate for national autonomy and related elements rather than

[18] The first public response from China on "de-risking" was aired by then Chinese Foreign Minister Qin Gang during his visit to Berlin in early May of 2023, one month after Macron and von de Leyen's China visit. See Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs (2023a). During this Europe trip, Qin has visited France and Norway as well as Germany. But he had only mentioned European strategic autonomy in France. See Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs (2023b).

[19] Viktor Orban, the right-wing populist Prime Minister of Hungary, considers the essence of EU-SA as "not copy(ing) the foreign policy of the American Democrats". See MTI-Hungary Today (2024).

promoting a unified EU. China claims that the rise of populism is a symptom of Western social and political malaise and sometimes takes advantage of the symptom to divide the West and to defend its own regime (The Economist 2018; Financial Times 2023). On the other hand, far left and right politicians in the European Parliament and in the Member States are indeed less critical of China and Russia (Szicherle et al. 2021; Kastner 2023). Nevertheless, research finds that while populist-led governments appeared to be more China-friendly than non-populist governments, the impact of populism is not direct but mediated through other variables, namely, thick ideology, economic pragmatism and international positioning (Jakimów et al. 2024). China's impact on EU-SA through European populist forces remains ambiguous.

Generally speaking, in terms of the China–Europe relationship, almost all forces involved have been tactically taken advantage of EU-SA to serve their own interest and worldview. This has actually led to the simultaneous constructing and deconstructing of EU-SA.

4.2 European approach vs. Chinese model

States interact with each other as they politically mediate the churn of uneven development, and such process is getting more contentious during world order transition, hence forth the enhanced role of state and the emergence of various type of state capitalism. EU-SA is a strategy for the European production network to adjust and safeguard the European Approach. But on a global scale, the EU must interact with other forms of state capitalism, most notably the Chinese model. The interaction between the European Approach and the Chinese Model can be divided into three non-exclusive groups:(1) competitive emulation in the context of geoeconomic and geopolitical rivalry; (2) peer group learning and mimetic behavior; (3) enabling and mutual reinforcement.[20] Smooth compatibility between the European and the Chinese political economies will not be achieved before a new historic bloc of the new world order is built.

(1) Competitive emulation. The rebirth of industrial policy in the US and Western European countries is said to be related to the "increasing competitive threat posed by China on world markets" (Aiginger and Rodrik 2020). French president Macron vowed that "(w)e are determined…to transform the eurozone, which is today a monetary zone, into a true economic zone, powerful and capable of rivaling China and the US" (Gutteridge 2017). The European Commission's important competitiveness strategy in September 2024 has clearly taken inspiration from the US and China (European Commission 2024, 2).

(2) Peer learning. The EU has been using China's "socialist market economy" as an excuse for its trade defense policies since 2017, when the EU published the first trade distortion report on China (European Commission 2017). Scholars point out that the rise of EU industrial policy since the mid-2010s has given the EU a

[20] See Alami and Dixon (2024, 113–140).

similar hue to that of "Developmental Network States" (Carlo and Schmitz 2023). It is interesting to note that some European politicians even underline the similarity between China and Europe so as to sell their protectionist policies to the Chinese. For instance, during his visit to China in October 2023, Borrell (2023b) argued: "President Xi expressed a similar view when he said in 2020 that 'China must build a domestic supply system that is independently controllable, secure and reliable so that self-circulation can be accomplished at critical moments'. It is de-risking with Chinese characteristics…".

(3) Mutual reinforcement. Scholars point out that the unique Chinese model has prompted significant reorganization of the rules governing capitalism on global scale. They argue that the best explanation for the reactions from advanced countries to the evolution of China's political economy into "party-state capitalism" is security dilemma dynamics (Pearson et al. 2022). The reality is more complex than that. First, the West's protectionist urge has likewise prompted China to react. Second, both China and Europe have benefited heavily from previous neoliberal globalization and will likely strive to maintain those advantages. During the China-EU summit of 2022, Xi asked both sides to "explore more complementarities" between "China's new development philosophy" and the EU's "trade policy for open strategic autonomy" (Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs 2022a). Borrell noted in a speech in 2023: "We do not want to fuel fragmentation in the world; splitting it into two blocs or eco-systems" (Borrell 2023c). Third, the mutual reinforcement between Chinese and Western political economies does not follow a linear path. For example, after the Euro crisis, Germany's export-oriented capital successfully re-oriented itself towards the emerging markets, particularly China. Since 2017, however, this re-orientation has faced growing limitations due to the Europe' s lagging behind in technological innovation as well as three reasons related to China: demand for German exports in emerging economies has weakened in part due to China's strategy to substitute foreign technology; Chinese producers have concomitantly advanced into high-tech markets in which German export-oriented manufacturing has traditional strengths; a potential comprehensive technological decoupling between the US and China in the face of spiraling geopolitical rivalries would compromise Germany's ability to export to global markets even further (Schneider 2023a, b). Thus, building up the European common market in name of EU-SA will help Germany enlarge and enhance its industrial base in the face of fierce completion from China. That is the reason why Germany is willing to adjust its ordo-liberal economic dictum and come to terms with France's more statist proposals such as state aid on the European level.

4.3 Big picture in mind

EU-SA is the EU's attempt to build regional hegemony and expand its room to maneuver in the world arena. Almost all major powers have noticed EU-SA. Though US officials have avoided publicly commenting on EU-SA, some US strategists, by praising the idea of EU-SA, nevertheless have urged Europe to gang up with the US against China and Russia (Haddad and Polyakova 2018). As the Europeans fiercely debated where they should stand between China and the US, the late Henry

Kissinger, arguably the most revered US strategist, warned that a divided Atlantic would turn Europe into "an appendage of Eurasia" (Luce 2018).

Likewise, Chinese view of EU-SA has been heavily contaminated by their concern of the US. Beijing believes that the goal of EU-SA is for Europe to become an independent pole in the world. By supporting EU-SA, China wants to build a robust relationship with the EU and promote a multipolar world, echoing their joint opposition to the U.S. unilateral invasion of Iraq in 2003. For example, after receiving French President Macron in Beijing in April 2023, Xi told the press that China always views Europe as an independent pole in a multipolar world. China supports Europe in achieving strategic autonomy, upholds that the China–Europe relationship is not targeted at, subjugated to, or controlled by any third party, and believes that Europe will take an independent approach to developing its relations with China, he said (Xinhua 2023b). Some Chinese diplomats have taken an even more blunt approach. Fu Cong, then Chinese ambassador to the EU, asked: "why does it (Europe) have to listen to the US all the time?" (Stevis-Gridneff and Erlangerm 2023). He pointed out on another occasion: "We do not oppose the development of relations between the EU and the US, but not at the expense of China's interests" (The Chinese Mission to the EU 2023).

In the Chinese eyes, another more subtle "third party" is Russia. China is afraid that China–Europe relations will be derailed by war in Ukraine. On March 7, 2022, two weeks after the outbreak of the war, Chinese top diplomat Wang Yi was asked in a press conference: "Does China believe that its ever closer relations with Russia and the conflict in Ukraine may affect its relations with Europe and the EU?" When answering the question, Wang for the first time articulated that "the China–Europe relationship is not targeted at any third party, nor is it subjugated to or controlled by any third party" (Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs 2022b). In the virtual summit with the EU three weeks later, Xi remarked on Russia's relationship with Europe and NATO: "China supports Europe, especially the EU, in playing a primary role" in building up "a balanced, effective and sustainable security framework in Europe" (Chinese Ministry of Foreign Affairs 2022a).

Over the past few years, the EU has developed a dedicate approach to deal with complicated big power relations based on EU-SA.

First, the EU aims to keep the US military umbrella in Europe as long as possible while building up Europe's own defense capabilities. Europe cannot protect itself on its own with a war at its doorstep. The possibility of another Trump presidency has prompted the EU to increase its military investments. European politicians, however, have been carefully saying that European military build-up is a complementation of NATO.[21] By early 2024, when the US presidential election was approaching, European politicians used "strategic responsibility" rather than "strategic autonomy" so as not to agitate the Americans (Borrell 2024).

Second, the EU relentlessly bargains with the US on cost sharing while enhancing transatlantic economic coordination in response to China. Since Joe Biden took office as the US president in 2021, the EU and the US has enhanced greatly their

[21] For example, Baerbock et al. (2024).

coordination on China, especially on economic issues. Bilateral mechanism Trade and Technology Council (TTC) and multilateral platform the Group of 7 (G7) are two cases that illustrate this point. The EU Member States that have strong economic ties with China, such as Germany and the Netherlands, have been under particular pressure from Washington. But the EU has not unconditionally subsumed to US interests. The EU seems resolute that the US must contribute its fair share. For example, in order to counter China's leadership in 5G, the U.S. launched the Open Radio Access Network (Open RAN) and freed up $1.5 billion in funding to cultivate this emerging technology domestically. In an effort to win European support, the U.S. has involved Swedish firm Ericsson in domestic projects (Pollet 2024). As another example, in order to compensate for the losses caused by technology export controls on China, the US has engaged the Netherlands more deeply in the US-led global semiconductor industry. At the end of 2023, Dutch Prime Minister traveled to the US with an economic delegation on a "semiconductor industry tour" (netherlandsandyou.nl 2023).

Third, the EU emphasizes its independence and importance among great powers. The EU has been asking China to treat it more seriously, not judging it as a "third party". Before his visit to China in October 2023, HR/VP Josep Borrell pointed out that his "fist objective" of the trip was to reaffirm to China that Europe takes China seriously and "at the same time, we expect from China to take us more seriously and stop looking at us through the lens of its relations with others". "Our assessment and conduct is driven by our own interests," he added (Bermingham 2023b, c). Borrell also reminded the Chinese in his Beijing trip that Russian president Putin's decision to invade Ukraine was an opportunity to show it would be "a mistake to underestimate Europe's capabilities and its global role" (Borrell 2023d).

Fourth, the EU retains a degree of flexibility and openness in relations with China. In an EU summit in June 2023, European leaders concluded that the EU and China "have a shared interest in pursuing constructive and stable relations, anchored in respect for the rules-based international order, balanced engagement and reciprocity" (Soler 2023). European politicians realize that, unlike Russia, China is "a real systemic actor" within the global arena. With its economy approaching 20% of the world total and continuing to grow, China stands in stark contrast to Russia, which accounts for only about 2% and is in decline (Borrell 2023a).

The starting point of Europe's foreign policy is its existing and possible future position in the world system. Among the three biggest continental powers, Europe's economic performance lags behind China and the US. However, in the US–China global competition for centrality in four interrelated networks spanning from infrastructure, digital, production to finance (Schindler et al. 2024), the EU has the potential to be a king-maker. For the time being, the EU seems to have a realistic goal of safeguarding its position in the global core of capitalism, rather than stealing hegemony from the US or helping the US as best as it can to stem the rise of China. The EU is willing to align itself with the US because it believes that the US, although sometimes unreliable, is still the country whose values are closest to its own. The EU acknowledges that the multipolar world represented by China and Russia is "a major and urgent challenge" for Europe (European Commission and High Representative of the EU for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy 2021b, 1).

However, the EU is able to distinguish between the priorities of the US and its own, and is pragmatic in its approach to the US. Unlike the US, Europe does not have a leading technological position, nor does it have the power to subsidize companies on a large scale. Therefore, Europe's main purpose is supply chain diversification rather than occupying the technological high ground like the US (Bland et al. 2024). Furthermore, Europe is more eager to sustain multilateral system than the US, since the EU is composed of a group of small countries whose interests will be better protected through multilateralism rather than through arbitrary power dynamics.

It is worth noting that both China and the EU still see the US as a pivot and priority in their foreign policy. This shows that the US is still regarded on many occasions as a hegemon, though crippled, in the world system. During order transition, Europe will be divided into two groups: those who accept the fragmentation of the previous liberal international order and those who reject it. However, both groups look across the Atlantic Ocean for inspiration. When a liberal and a Europhile US president is in the White House, Europe is likely to be ruled by Atlanticists. This is considered by China as the most unfavorable situation. When the US president pushes for more fragmentation of the world order, nationalists and Europeanists (EU-SA supporters) might gain an upper hand in European politics (See Table 4).

5 Conclusion

The article seeks to explore China's role in Europe's pursuit of strategic autonomy and to understand big power relations such as China–Europe relations during world order transition in a broader sense.

EU-SA is the EU's strategy to navigate through order transition and to maintain its values and interests in the upcoming order. During the period of world order transition, which began roughly around the global financial crisis in 2008, the hegemon, i.e., the US's simultaneous grip of ideas, institutions and material capabilities loosened up, while nonhegemonic powers scrambled to build a new historical structure. The role of state became more prevalent during this period. The EU is not a state, but it faces the similar task of enhancing its autonomy. Thus EU-SA is a hegemonic game both inside and beyond the EU. EU-SA begins as a collection of ideas, but gradually develops into institutions and capabilities. Therefore EU-SA concerns other major powers, including China. Meanwhile, relationship between major powers during world order transition becomes more volatile, since everyone is trying to assert its own hegemonic strategy by building up coalitions and taking advantage of cleavages. The interaction between China and the EU over EU-SA takes place on three interrelated levels: social forces, forms of state and global order.

The article has applied an analysis framework (two triangles) related to historical structure developed by Robert W. Cox to illustrate how the China factor has been included in the dynamics of EU-SA. The first triangle consists of three elements building up a historical structure: ideas, institutions and material capabilities. The second triangle consists of three spheres of activities (or three levels of analysis) where the elements interact: social forces, forms of state, world orders.

Table 4 European reactions to the fragmentation of the liberal international order. Source: Costa and Barbé (2023)

	Nationalists	Atlanticists		Europeanists
		If US admin Atlanticist	If US admin not Atlanticist	
Acceptance	Fragmented order of sovereign nations Euroscepticism Transactional re-alignment with other great powers	The West vs the Rest Actorness requires greater operational strategic autonomy EU as a responsible partner in a struggling West	The Rest vs a divided West Actorness demands greater operational and industrial strategic autonomy Hope of getting the US back. No deterrent	Competing regional blocks Actorness requires operational, industrial and decisional strategic autonomy Independent EU, including deterrent
Rejection	Global order of sovereign nations Only available to big players "Global Britain"	Continuity under more difficult conditions No remarkably higher requirements for actorness Confidence in US capacities EU-US bilateralism as leverage to reform/defend the LIO	*When hope vanishes, move to next column*	Cooperative regional orders Actorness requires operational, industrial and decisional autonomy. But deterrent not critical bc order is perceived as less conflictual EU as mender of the LIO through multiple coalitions

We can draw conclusions about China's role in EU-SA and China–Europe relations as follows.

First, competition between China and Europe is becoming increasingly fierce. By 2022, the year when the Ukraine war broke out, European politicians have identified three areas they wanted to seek autonomy from China: values, economic security and strategic security. The EU has been building up institutions to bolster EU-SA goals. Though there is a gap between ambition and capabilities, EU-SA is not a failure. Without exerting itself too much into the world, the EU has nevertheless been able to maintain what it previously established.

Second, Europe and China are both "subject" and "object" for each other. Thanks to several decades of deep globalization and the rapid rise of China, Europe and China have become intricately interconnected. Almost all forces involved in China–Europe relations –various capital and labor sectors, different EU institutions, different Member States, etc.—have been taken tactical advantage of EU-SA to serve their own interest and worldview. This has actually led to the simultaneous construction and deconstruction of EU-SA.

Third, the "Chinese model" and the "European Approach" have been echoing and influencing each other. EU-SA is a strategy for the European production network to adjust and safeguard the European Approach. But on the global scale, the EU has to interact with other forms of capitalism, most notably the Chinese model. The interaction involves competitive emulation, peer learning and mutual reinforcement. In general, the EU wants to strike a balance between defending the EU from Chinese "distorted economy" and seeking "reciprocity" in the Chinese market by championing free trade.

Fourth, China–Europe relations have been strongly influenced by other big powers. The most notable "third party" is the US. The US has urged Europe to gang up with it against China and Russia. Likewise, Chinese view of EU-SA has been heavily contaminated by their concern of the US. The EU has developed a dedicated approach to deal with complicated big power relations based on EU-SA, aiming to retain a degree of flexibility and openness in its dealings with great powers. For the time being, the EU seems to have a realistic goal of safeguarding its position in the global core of capitalism, rather than stealing hegemony from the US or helping the US to stem the rise of China. The EU is willing to align itself with the US because it believes that the US, although sometimes unreliable, is still the country whose values are closest to its own. However, the EU is able to distinguish between the priorities of the US and its own, and is pragmatic in its approach to the US.

We can further conclude the characteristics of nonhegemonic power relations during world order transition in general. This topic, having not been scrutinized by Cox, is a contribution to the critical IPE theory.

First, the adjustment of relations between major powers is a fluid, multi-dimensional and open-ended process. Nonhegemonic powers, when they find that they have entered world power transition, will try to build a new historic structure buttressing a world order that best supports their ideology and interests. The task will be conducted by a group of like-minded elites representing the interests of particular classes or sectors. They will try to build new coalitions and take advantage of

cleavages on social, national and global levels. They have to fight with other group of elites both inside and outside their countries. Hegemonic politics, encompassing ideas, institutions and material capabilities, will last for years until a new hegemony is built first within a principal country and then around the world.

Second, nonhegemonic powers will try to maintain flexibility in their relationship as long as possible until a clear historic bloc emerges toward the end of order transition; therefore, their relations reflect a large bandwidth of fuzzy logics. For example, they will apply simultaneously trade-related logics from unconditional free trade, trade-security bargaining to restriction and coercion. It is easier to cultivate relationships defined by fuzzy logic with nonhegemonic powers that possess varying degrees of influence and uncertain attitudes toward the changing world order.

Third, the principal power that has the potential to become the next hegemon or a non-excludable member of the hegemonic coalition will be an influential player during world order transition. This power is better equipped to form blocs and networks during world order transition. Normally more than one of such principal powers will emerge during world order transition. The relationship between such two principal powers will play a highly consequential role, though not necessary a decisive one, in building up new world order.

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Declarations

Conflict of interest The author declares that there is no competing interest regarding the publication of this article.

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